

1 Thessalonians, Part 2

Holy living and resurrection hope

BIG IDEA Because Christ will return and raise his people, believers pursue holiness, love, hope, and watchful faithfulness.

Purpose and outcome

By the end of the lesson, the class should be able to:

- explain why Paul connects Christ's return with sexual holiness, brotherly love, responsible work, and public witness;
- describe Christian grief as real grief transformed by resurrection hope;
- summarize Paul's central promise about believers who have died: they will rise and share fully in Christ's coming;
- distinguish watchful faithfulness from date-setting and speculative end-times systems; and
- identify how a congregation encourages, tests, serves, and pursues holiness while waiting for Christ.

Lesson at a glance

TIME	MOVEMENT
0:00–4:00	Opening prayer and Lesson 6 recap
4:00–8:00	Orient the class to 1 Thessalonians 4–5
8:00–16:00	Holy living while we wait — 4:1–12
16:00–29:00	Grieving with resurrection hope — 4:13–18
29:00–38:00	The Day of the Lord and watchful faithfulness — 5:1–11
38:00–44:00	A waiting church lives together — 5:12–22
44:00–47:00	The faithful God sanctifies — 5:23–24
47:00–50:00	The Gospel Then and Now, next reading, and prayer

Before class

Write on the board: “How should Christ's return change the way we live today?” Have 1 Thessalonians 4:1–12; 4:13–18; 5:1–11; and 5:12–24 marked. Use one reader and participants' own Bibles or apps. The lesson is self-contained for those who did not complete the reading.

CORE READINGS Read 1 Thessalonians 4:1–12; 4:13–18; 5:1–11; and 5:23–24. Summarize 5:12–22 if time is short.

1. CORE — Holy living while we wait

Read 1 Thessalonians 4:1–12. Paul moves from celebrating visible faith to urging continued growth. “More and more” appears in 4:1 and 4:10: this is a faithful church that still needs to mature.

- God's will is their sanctification (4:3). Holiness is not an optional advanced course; it belongs to God's call and is empowered by the Holy Spirit (4:7–8).
- Sexual holiness means refusing to treat another person as an object for desire or exploitation. Paul calls believers to exercise self-control in holiness and honor.
- God has already taught them to love one another, yet Paul urges them to do so “more and more.” Grace-produced love continues to grow.
- The quiet life of 4:11 is not withdrawal from mission. It means attending responsibly to one's own work, refusing disruptive dependence, and maintaining a credible witness before outsiders.
- Paul's commands arise from belonging to God. The gospel's indicative remains underneath the imperative: God calls, gives his Spirit, and forms a holy people.

TEACHING LINE Waiting for Christ is not an excuse to withdraw from ordinary faithfulness. Christian hope makes holiness, love, work, and witness matter more.

2. CORE — Grieving with resurrection hope

Read 1 Thessalonians 4:13–18. Some believers apparently feared that Christians who died before Christ returned would miss the blessings of his coming. Paul does not shame their grief; he corrects the hopelessness that can govern grief.

- The foundation is the gospel: Jesus died and rose again (4:14). The future of those united to Christ rests on what God has already done in Christ.
- “Sleep” is a common biblical and ancient euphemism for death. The image stresses death’s temporary character for believers; the paragraph does not settle every question about the intermediate state.
- The dead in Christ are not disadvantaged. They rise first, and living believers join them. The pastoral emphasis is shared participation, not competition over order.
- “Caught up” describes a real gathering to Christ. The English word “rapture” comes through the Latin translation of this verb, but this paragraph alone does not supply a complete end-times timetable.
- The climax is not the cloud, trumpet, or sequence: “And so we will be with the Lord forever.” Paul ends with a command to encourage one another.

LOOK CLOSER Parousia, translated “coming,” could describe the arrival or presence of a ruler. Apantēsis, translated “meet,” could be used for going out to welcome an arriving dignitary. These associations illuminate the royal welcome, but they should not be forced into a detailed travel itinerary.

3. CORE — Watchful faithfulness

Read 1 Thessalonians 5:1–11. Paul says the Thessalonians do not need a timetable. The Day of the Lord will come unexpectedly like a thief and unavoidably like labor pains. His concern is readiness, not calculation.

- The Day of the Lord draws on Old Testament language for God’s decisive intervention in judgment and salvation.
- Believers are “children of the light” and “children of the day.” Paul grounds the command to stay awake in the identity God has already given them.
- Watchfulness means sober, faithful living. Paul’s armor is faith and love as a breastplate and the hope of salvation as a helmet—the same faith, love, and hope praised in 1:3.
- The gospel answer appears in 5:9–10: God did not appoint believers to wrath but to receive salvation through Jesus Christ, who died for them.
- Paul again ends with mutual encouragement: “encourage one another and build each other up.” Eschatology should strengthen the church, not fracture it.

GUARDRAIL Do not turn “times and dates” into the center of a passage that explicitly redirects believers from prediction to readiness. Teach what Paul uses the doctrine to accomplish: hope, sobriety, courage, and mutual encouragement.

4. CORE — A waiting church lives together

Summarize 5:12–22. Paul’s rapid commands show what watchfulness looks like inside a congregation.

- Respect those who labor and lead, and live at peace with one another (5:12–13).
- Different people need different care: warn the idle, encourage the discouraged, help the weak, and be patient with everyone (5:14).
- Reject retaliation; pursue what is good; rejoice, pray, and give thanks within God’s will in Christ (5:15–18).
- Do not quench the Spirit or despise prophecies, but test everything. Openness and discernment belong together (5:19–22).
- The holy kiss and the public reading of the letter (5:26–27) reflect a familial, gathered church in which every believer receives the apostolic word.

5. CORE — The faithful God sanctifies

Read 5:23–24. Paul turns his commands into prayer. He asks the God of peace to sanctify his people through and through and preserve them for Christ’s coming. The church’s hope finally rests in God’s character: “The one who calls you is faithful, and he will do it.”

TEACHING LINE Christian obedience is serious, but Christian assurance does not rest on our ability to finish ourselves. The faithful God who calls his people is also at work sanctifying them.

The Gospel Then and Now

MOVEMENT	CHURCH APPLICATION
Church reality then	Believers faced sexual pressures, bereavement, uncertainty about Christ's return, disruptive behavior, and the ordinary strains of congregational life.
Church temptation now	We can separate future hope from present holiness, grieve as though death has the final word, chase prophetic timetables, or use disagreement about the end times to divide the church.
Gospel-shaped church	Because Jesus died, rose, and will return, the church grieves with hope, lives in holiness and love, works responsibly, tests carefully, and encourages one another.

Discussion

1. How should Christ's return change the way we live today?
2. What is the difference between grieving and grieving without hope?
3. Why does Paul answer questions about Christ's return with commands to encourage one another?
4. What does watchfulness look like if it does not mean calculating dates?
5. Why must a church both welcome the Spirit's work and "test everything"?
6. Where do we need the assurance that "the one who calls you is faithful, and he will do it"?

Scholarly notes and guardrails

- Control one's body — The wording in 4:4 can be understood as controlling one's own body or acquiring/living with a wife. Do not let the translation question obscure Paul's clear demand for sexual holiness and honor.
- According to the Lord's word — Paul may be drawing on Jesus' teaching, a saying preserved outside the Gospels, or direct revelation. The source is uncertain; the authority of the promise is not.
- Sleep — Treat it as pastoral imagery for deceased believers, not as a complete doctrine of the soul's condition between death and resurrection.
- Rapture — The passage teaches that believers will be caught up to meet Christ. It does not by itself establish the timing of that gathering relative to every other end-times event.
- Meet the Lord — Ancient welcoming customs may inform the image, but avoid claiming that one Greek word settles whether believers immediately continue upward or escort Christ toward earth.
- Day of the Lord — Keep both judgment and salvation in view. Paul's practical answer is not fear or prediction but identity-shaped vigilance.
- Sanctified through and through — This is a prayer for God's comprehensive preserving work, not a quick proof-text for instant sinless perfection.

Leader preparation

Commentary and further study: Gene L. Green, *The Letters to the Thessalonians* (Pillar New Testament Commentary); John Stott, *The Message of 1 & 2 Thessalonians*; Life Application Bible Commentary: 1 & 2 Thessalonians; and the notes in the NIV Study Bible, ESV Study Bible, or NIV Biblical Theology Study Bible.

Online resource: BibleProject, Book of 1 Thessalonians Guide — bibleproject.com/guides/book-of-1-thessalonians/

ECO connection: Essential Tenet III.C (covenant life in the church) and III.E (living in obedience to the Word of God).

Official text: eco-pres.org/constitution/

Before Lesson 8: Start with 2 Thessalonians 1 and 2:1–17. If possible, read the entire three-chapter letter. Notice how Paul addresses persecution, confusion about the Day of the Lord, and disorderly living.

LIKELY RABBIT TRAILS The intermediate state, competing rapture timelines, identifying every trumpet or cloud, calculating dates, and importing the "man of lawlessness" from 2 Thessalonians before the class reaches that letter. Name the limits of this text and return to Paul's pastoral commands: grieve with hope, stay awake, and encourage one another.